

changes feel silly and uncomfortable, that impulse control comes from the brain. That means taking care of your brain will give you a better capacity to resist impulsivity, which leads to less impulse spending.

Social Influence

During our home renovation I (still Jen) followed a lot of interior design influencers on social media. I have little to no eye for design, but I'm also very picky. That basically translates to having a lot of opinions on other people's designs but not being able to come up with one of my own. Not a good combination. So, I was hoping these women, who could turn an empty room into a work of art with what I truly believe is sorcery, would help me articulate the design I wanted. The great thing about watching a ten-second video is that once the video is done the room is complete. But not once did anyone tell me how to figure out what "complete" is. I became overwhelmed trying to haphazardly re-create their perfect room, and because mine wasn't identical I didn't know when I was done. There was always one more picture or one more potted plant to buy.

When we strive for perfection, good is never good enough. Perfect curations on social media mean we're always buying the next thing to complete our lives to make them "perfect." One or two skin-care products aren't enough; you must have every product for every problem. One dress for spring is okay, but a haul of fifteen different dresses for the season is better! We know social media is a highlight reel, but that hasn't stopped it from fueling our perfectionism and the idea that the grass is greener on the other side.

But perfect doesn't exist. And even if it did, achieving it is nowhere on our list of internal needs. You can have everything you love with mismatched cutlery, an unaesthetic car, and laminate countertops. Water tastes great in the water bottle you already have, and a cozy blanket feels great on your couch, no matter how ugly you may think it is. The first step in overcoming socially influenced impulse spending is to stop wanting what other people have. No thing you can buy will make your life or home remotely close to perfect. So why waste money trying? Instead, maybe we start embracing an unaesthetic life. Stop being afraid of how our old dining table looks in pictures and celebrate all the times we get to share dinners on